

Corsair Carbide SPEC Alpha

A radical shift in computer cabinet design

Gaming cabinets from Alienware stayed true to their name by offering futuristic design elements that certainly gave an impression of alien tech. On the same lines, the exteriors of the SPEC Alpha looks no less. Highly reminiscent of the turrets from the video game Portal, the cabinet feet play a big role in giving it that distinct look. They also ensure there's a considerable distance from the floor for air intake from the bottom (if you install a case fan). If these feet don't impress you then you can buy aftermarket rubber feet and attach them in the provided holes at the bottom. Before going into the regular internal components of the case, there's one glaring change that needs to be addressed – the optical disc drive slot has been completely removed. This might not bother you much if your DVD drive has been collecting dust ever since you built your system. If you don't have the luxury of a high-speed internet connection, you would still be dependent on physical DVDs for software and games. But this shouldn't be really a concern since USB-powered external DVD drives are available that aren't really expensive. This decision for a paradigm shift wasn't the company's alone and in fact, the request was honoured after feedback from customers.

Apart from this, the interiors remain the same compared to the previous Spec cabinets. The front and top panels have an angled design, both meshed. The front panel comes with two 120mm fans with sliding slits, in case you plan on adding a third fan at the bottom. The top panel can house two 120mm fans as well, but there's not enough room to fit in a radiator. These fans can be controlled with the three-speed fan controller on the front panel. To be able to reach and install the third fan, you'll have to remove the drive cage that houses three HDD slots and two SSD brackets, and additional two SSD brackets can be found behind the motherboard plate. If you plan on replacing the stock fans with aftermarket coolers and radiators, or even if you want to install a second GPU (310mm in length), you will have to remove the drive cage. Installing HDDs and SSDs won't require any tools. The cabinet offers a generous numbers of tie-slits and paths for cable management, except for the CPU power cable that wouldn't fit through the top right corner cutout.

The side-window panel has a transparent plexi-glass which is susceptible to scratches so you'll



need to be extra careful while handling it. The thumbscrews don't fall off their grooves, clinging to them which is good and should be adopted by all cabinet manufacturers. On the other hand, we weren't able to screw in the side-window thumbscrews on the review unit we received, and we hope that this problem persists only on our unit. This also made the panel leave a wide gap at the front, making it look defective. One more concern that bothered was about not having any grooves to pick up the cabinet. The meshes on the top and front panel don't have any dust filters and you'll find one only at the bottom.

The absence of the optical disc drive certainly improves the airflow, even with the stock fans. With the fans spinning at full speed, the 4960X lay stable at 62 degrees having Prime95 run for five minutes. FurMark is quite intensive and the Radeon HD 7790 heated up to 60 degrees in the preset settings (burn in switched off). Measuring the temperature zones revealed that the CPU area stayed cool at around 40 degrees which wasn't a surprise because of the front intake fans and the rear exhaust fan working together. In full potential, which is three fans at the front, two on the top, one at the bottom and one at the rear, airflow will immensely improve and make the enclosure far cooler.

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Specifications

Motherboard form factor: ATX and Micro-ATX; **PSU form factor:** ATX standard; **Front I/O:** 2 x USB 3.0, Mic in and Audio Out, 3-speed fan control; **Drive options:** 3 x 3.5-inch HDD, 4 x 2.5-inch SSD; **Fans:** 3 x 120mm

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